

KF8 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

If you are benefiting from this ministry, we invite you to return a financial gift in proportion to your financial resources. This is *karis*, the Greek word for grace, which we now understand as a relationship with others based on mutual generosity. In KF, we learn to respond to God’s gifts by returning a gift that represents our gratitude. We also learn to respond to one another with karis generosity. Find **Give a Gift** at the top right of the KF website home page. You can offer a one-time gift to Karis Fellowships, or you can select the option to make an automated donation.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We might thank Alison, who created the original Karis Fellowships website as a gift to the KF community. Alison has donated much of her time and skill to the organization and design of this ministry. She and her husband explored the mindfulness training that was offered in their community and then brought to KF some of the practices that they had learned, including the **3-Minute Breathing Space** and a prototype of the **FAITH Process**. We are grateful for their contribution. We recommend that you seek extra mindfulness training in your own community and online. Websites like meditationoasis.com and headspace.com may help you develop a practice that works for you. You can also look for guided meditations on YouTube.

The Maranatha Meditation¹

Begin by sitting still and as upright as you can. Breathe as you lightly close your eyes. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Silently, within your own mind, begin to slowly say the word *MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA*. *Maranatha* is Aramaic for *Come, Lord*. Pay attention to the word as you explore what works for you. You might try saying two syllables on the inhale and two on the exhale. Or, if you wish, you can pace your breath and attend to all four syllables on the inhale and to all four syllables on the exhale. You can explore that now. *(Pause for 30 seconds)* To help you endure, I will remind you of the word *maranatha* once during our three-minute meditation. Relax into the word as you continue to observe your breath, and begin. *(Pause for 3 minutes with a reminder of the word at 1.5 minutes)*

Pause. Take a deep breath and open your eyes. Gently draw your mind back to the meeting. You might begin practicing this meditation for twenty minutes in the morning and then again later in the day.

Remember that the struggle to focus strengthens your ability to be mindful, just as the struggle to lift a weight makes you strong.

Our hymn, *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord* describes normal life events that happen to everyone. Mindfulness training helps us endure productively so that in all of life's events we can respond by doing things God's way.

When I am sad at heart, teach me Thy way!
When earthly joys depart, teach me Thy way!
In hours of loneliness, in times of dire distress,
In failure or success, teach me Thy way!²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

(Optional) When we find ourselves in experiments and events, the key to our healing is to observe, confess, and work on our own misorientation. We cannot heal ourselves if we are focused on the misorientation of others.

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are exploring KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by our Creator.

Pull out your **Two Paths Flowchart** once again. We would like to remind you to keep practicing the tools that you have learned so far. You now have several tools to help you maintain your orientation to God and to your True Self. It's not enough to have the tools in your toolbox, however. You must develop the skill to use those tools, and that takes time and practice.

Let's review some points that will help clarify our mission in Karis Fellowships.

1. Our purpose in KF

You are working to reclaim the glory that your Creator intended for you. You are His child, an heir of your Father's house, but the world, the flesh, and the devil still hold you captive.³ In order to reveal His glory, you will need to co-labor with God to ransom the creature that He created, which is your True Self. Co-laboring with God in that process may require much of your resources right now. The ransom of your True Self cost Jesus a great deal, but Jesus thought you were worth it. Do you? Our book, *Neurosis and Human Growth*, tells us why we often do not think we are worth it.⁴ So, part of our work in Karis Fellowships is to develop a new vision of ourselves as individuals who are of inestimable value to God and have an essential mission in this material world.

2. The Two Paths Flowchart—living in love or judgment

Over the next few weeks, we will be looking closely at how to use this flowchart.

3. The event or the day of judgment

James refers to events as *experiments*, and we can also apply John's phrase, *the day of judgment*. The purpose of these pesky life experiments is not to condemn or shame us; the purpose of these experiments is revelation. Life events examine and reveal the quality of our trust and our trustworthiness. We can welcome these experiments because *God must reveal the problem before He can heal the problem. (Repeat)* And we want to heal.

4. Feelings are not meant to be our primary motivators

Feelings are just feelings. They are untrustworthy guides for knowing what is good and evil. We know this because the same event can affect people in different ways. Some will judge an event as good, and others will judge the same event as evil. Nancy has seen people completely change their own evaluation of an event after a brief discussion or after doing some healing work. It seems like a miracle. What twenty minutes ago felt so evil now feels good to that same person.

5. The fear of death is the source of all unhealthy fear

All living things react to the environment. If your environment presents a threat, you will react. These reactions often spring from the fear of losing your idealized life. This fear is the fear of death. The author of Hebrews writes that, without Jesus, all human creatures are enslaved to the fear of death throughout their lives. The fear of death, and the compelling need to escape that fear, is like a black hole that sucks all the energy and delight from our lives. Let's look at **Hebrews 2:14–15** in Nancy's translation.

¹⁴Therefore, since the children share in flesh and blood, Jesus Himself likewise also shared the same limitations so that through death He might render powerless the one who had the power of death, that is, the devil or accuser, ¹⁵and might liberate those who have been enslaved all of their lives because of their fear of death.

Take a deep breath.

When our search for glory is endangered, we experience intense feelings of frustration and threat; when we imagine that we have escaped our fear and are on our way to an idealized glory, we feel euphoric. Both of these reactions, however, are rooted in fear. Whether we are afraid or euphoric, the deep fear of death keeps our beautiful energy focused on saving our lives and our pride. We then unconsciously force that focus onto those around us. We try to conscript them into supporting us in our efforts to save the life of our Idol Self. Unfortunately, by conscripting others, we sometimes succeed in getting our own way, and this encourages us to believe that we have saved ourselves and escaped from death. As long as we are able to maintain this illusion, we are content. What a poor vision of happiness! Life is full of difficulties and mishaps. Happiness is not found in avoiding such things, but rather in knowing how to handle them.

Nancy's email address is nancy@karisfellowships.com. This week, you are invited to send her a list of your three greatest fears. She will send you an email to remind you. We will look at these fears anonymously in the weeks ahead and see what we can learn. How exciting!

Our prayer might go something like this:

Great Counselor, show me my real fears. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let’s continue with **James 1:5–8**. This is Nancy’s translation.

⁵But if anyone should find themselves lacking practical skill in situations, let them ask God about it. God generously gives practical help to everyone, and He gives without throwing their dysfunction back in their faces to shame and belittle them. God will give wisdom to the one who asks for skill to deal with situations, ⁶but that person must ask in faith. In other words, he or she must be ready to act upon what God shows them without any hesitancy or wavering; for the one who wavers is like the surf of the sea, driven and tossed by the wind. ⁷Such persons ought not to imagine that they will receive anything from the Lord, ⁸being double-minded, or of two spirits, and therefore, unstable in all their ways.

Take a deep breath.

1. Success is often more spiritually unstable than distress

Remember that in order to develop the True Self we need a long-tempered endurance. No matter what happens around you, your real goal is to develop the long-tempered endurance that will equip you to live your life gloriously. We often think that we need endurance most in times of fear or loss, but that’s not always the case. God usually has our attention in times of failure and during what our hymn calls “times of dire distress”.⁵ It is in times of success that the quality of our training is revealed, and when we experience success—when we get what we want, when we feel euphoric—we need to be especially mindful and aware. How often have we seen so-called successful people fail to build trustworthy, fulfilled lives?

You might imagine that you will naturally learn to handle success productively and find peace with the new status quo, but this also requires training. Success brings unprecedented experiences and changes that create tension, and this tension causes our Idol Self to react. Your ability to handle success with success is directly proportional to your ability to endure that tension. Let’s take as an example the tension that we experience when we are successful in our personal development. For mastery type Christians, to show heartfelt kindness or mercy is success, but in order to maintain this positive direction they must endure the tension that comes from forfeiting an opportunity to conquer and punish. When self-effacing types successfully stand up for themselves or assert their preferences, they must endure the tension of feeling selfish; they must resist the compulsion to give in, please, or apologize. When resigned types dare to touch an area of self-awareness and make some progress toward feeling their real feelings, they must endure the craving to escape into stagnation and numbness. God is regularly seeking to stretch your ability to live gloriously, but He can only do this if you are able to productively endure the tension created by change. God wants to explore with you as, together, you discover your potential. You are an eternally developing creature who is learning the ways of eternity.

2. The basic problem is our commitment—are we committed to our Idol or to God?

Trusting God’s wisdom requires training—training that prepares you to courageously act on the wisdom He offers. God cannot train you, however, if you are still committed to the judgment path;

you will refuse to follow through on His way of doing things. But remember this: if you continue to harbor divided loyalties, you are not simply choosing between judgment and love; at the heart of your choice is this question—*Who is your God?*

When we are committed to our Idol Self, we are committed to another god, and if we obey the fear and compulsive demands of the Idol, we are obeying another god. It's not hard to see that the Idol Self is just another god, so whenever you follow its guidance, you are breaking God's first commandment: "Thou shalt have no other gods before Me."⁶ When God confronts that problem in you, He is doing you a huge favor.

3. Two spirits are two masters

When we are torn between two masters, our instability becomes readily apparent, even to ourselves. We are not to be trusted. We talk about being a Christian, but neither the quality of our words nor our lives reflect that glorious new birth. We have not yet agreed within ourselves that God is who He says He is—the Creator and the only Lawgiver and Judge. We are not convinced that opposing Him has real consequences. We would rather gratify our pride than access and enjoy God as our ally.

4. Karis Fellowships gives us tools that help us become single-spirit people

Here is another way of describing our goal in KF: we are working toward becoming *single-spirit* people. No one can serve two masters.⁷ If you find that your life is full of unstable habits and relationships, if you make decisions but are regularly unable to follow them through, if you commit to training and then refuse to train, or if you have taken the name of Christian but choose to do your own thing, then you are like the surf of the sea, tossed back and forth by the winds of circumstances and feelings.⁸ Would you put your trust in that kind of sea? Would you trust that kind of person?

Hopefully, you are now willing to admit that you are tempted to serve two masters. You might tell God this week that you are ready to give up trying to be God and are willing to train your woefully underdeveloped True Self. When you give up the life of trying to be your own god and doing your own thing, you will be free to pursue your real potential as a glorious creature in karis relationship with the real God, who is love. This love is beyond all that you can ask or think, but it is not beyond what you can experience.

Our prayer might go something like this:

God and Creator, I am ready to be Your creature in karis relationship. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your stillness posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider living as a glorious creature serving the real God in a created world.*
(Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider living as a glorious creature serving the real God in a created world*, how does it feel? (Pause) Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. (Pause) Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush real feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. (Pause) Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider living as a glorious creature serving the real God in a created world*. Give yourself permission now to explore without judgment, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Lovingly notice what it is doing as you *consider living as a glorious creature serving the real God*. What sensations are there? (Pause) For example, you might notice what disbelief or potential feels like in your body. Breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider living as a glorious creature serving the real God in a created world*. Does that feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. (Pause) Do you judge the idea of glorious living as good or bad? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? (Pause) Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered living as a glorious creature serving the real God in a created world*. You are a human creature, and you are not alone in your feelings. (Pause) When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe and allow yourself to feel some compassion for everyone who embraces the possibility of real glory. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful for this time together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

There is a lot to learn and relearn as we renew our minds and thinking. You may wish to download and print out these teachings so that you can review them during your quiet moments, or you might ask admin to email you the **KF Compass**. You may also find it helpful to play back the recordings of these meetings and capture a few ideas to carry with you during the week.

¹ John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

² *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord* by Benjamin Mansell Ramsey (1849–1923), youtu.be/FmY6848ZQeo.

³ James 3:15.

⁴ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁵ *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord* by Benjamin Mansell Ramsey (1849–1923), youtu.be/FmY6848ZQeo.

⁶ Exod. 20:3.

⁷ Matt.6:24.

⁸ James 1:6.